

Creative Zen

Now That's What I Call... A Media Player

The Creative Zen media player looks cool with its glossy front finish and a shiny pixie-dust speckled black matte finish and scratch-resistant back. The glossy front does not collect too many fingerprints, contrary to what we've seen thus far. It is available in a variety of colours, so you can choose according to your taste.

It comes with 4 GB of Flash memory and is detected as a portable device that you can sync with using Windows Media Player or Winamp, or even transfer files using the Windows Explorer. It is also compatible with iTunes Plus Music and lets you download music and videos from subscription services. There is also an SD expansion slot for additional memory capacity.

The buttons are very responsive and react in an instant. There are dedicated buttons for context menu, playback / pause, back, and there is a four-way rocker to go forward and back and

control volume as well as navigate. The interface is extremely easy and intuitive—it's a joy to see the menus glide effortlessly as you click the buttons.

As is the case with most media players, you need to transcode your videos before they can be played by the Zen—this is achieved using the bundled Creative Media Explorer. Video is amazingly clear, crisp and vibrant, thanks to the 2.5 inch TFT display and the playback was smooth and comfortably easy on the eyes.

Music playback is definitely one of the best we have heard in a long time. The bundled earphones do an amazing job in reproducing even the bass, which is the most difficult to achieve for earbuds such as

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★●
Performance	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★●
Comfort	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●



these. We must add that they are a bit large and may trouble smaller ears. You can customise your own equaliser settings, or choose from eight presets. Bass Boost enhances bass and you would probably want to leave it turned on. Smart Volume, when turned on, protects your ears by normalising the volume in case of extreme loudness.

Now for some nuances: though the battery lasts for around 18 hours of MP3 playback, it could have done better if the LCD completely turned off during music playback (it dims, but stays on). There is not much to complain about, but a TV-Out option would have completed the package. The Zen has FM Radio with 32 preset stations and a voice

recorder. Other features include the organiser, with a calendar, tasks and contacts. It costs Rs 9,999, and we recommend it.

Specifications
Capacity: 4 GB; Display: 2.5-inch 16.7M colour TFT; Audio: MP3, WMA, AUDIBLE 2,3,4, AAC (unprotected); Photo: JPEG, BMP, TIF, PNG, GIF; Video: WMV9, MP4, DivX (converted using bundled software); FM Radio; Dimensions: 53 (W) x 10 (D) x 81 (H) mm; Weight: 60 gm

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Web site: www.creative.com
Price: Rs 9,999

Palm Treo 750

Palm-dows?

The Treo 750 is a Windows Mobile-based PDA phone that promises one handed operation. The new phone is tad slimmer, feels lighter and the curvy design helps hide the bulk. The dark midnight-blue finish with sliver highlights gives it an executive look. The volume control rocker is on the left hand side, while the IR port and memory slot is recessed on the right hand side of the phone. Other control buttons are neatly arranged around the navigational key.

The 2.5-inch LCD screen dominates the front, but we've seen bigger. The screen is sharp and completely legible in direct sunlight. The dinky QWERTY keypad still remains one of the best

we've seen so far.

The phone is powered by Windows Mobile 5—with a 300 MHz processor, it's a smart choice: Windows Mobile 6 requires a faster processor. In the memory department, the Treo 750 is definitely anaemic, and Windows' dodgy memory management doesn't help.

Palm has done its bit to revamp the interface and make it easy to navigate without touching the stylus; something we admire about Palm devices. The phone is

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★●
Performance	★★★★★
Ease of Use	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★★



generally zippy and applications open in a snap, but opening multiple applications takes its toll. We had no signal issues and voice clarity was good. The speakerphone quality is good, but the ringer volume needs improvement. The camera's image quality is merely average.

At Rs 22,990, the Treo 750 is expensive—competing models offer better feature sets at lower prices. Palm is giving away a free foldable

Bluetooth keyboard along with this phone, but it still doesn't make it worth it.

Specifications
7200 rpm SATA; USB 2.0; TurboUSB; Dimensions: 4.6 (W) x 16.3 (D) x 20(H) cm; Weight: 6.2 kg

Contact: Brightstar Telecom India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 011-41725228-9
E-mail: myil.nathar@palm.com
Web site: www.palm.com
Price: Rs 22,990

Sahara AL 096

Low On Frills, High On Price

The Sahara AL 096 is very solidly built and has a business-like look, with a grey-black finish and no decorations. The hinges are well-built and offer little play, which is a good thing. It weighs over 2.5 Kg—making it a little heavy to carry around.

Equipped with an older Core Duo processor and 1 GB of RAM, of which 256 MB is reserved for sharing, there is still enough power to handle normal office applications. The 120 GB hard drive offers ample storage space. A DVD multi-write drive takes care of backups. There are three USB ports for expansion, but no FireWire. WiFi and Ethernet ports are there, but Bluetooth is absent. A D-Sub port lets you hook up a projector for presentations.

The 17-inch widescreen LCD looks good and has a wide horizontal viewing angle, the vertical angle is a bit narrow. It has a matte finish, so it is easier to view it

even if the light source is at the front, as there is very little distracting reflection. The ATI RADEON Graphics label (mis)leads one to believe that there is discrete graphics inside, but it's really an onboard ATI XPRESS 200M graphics chip—good for 2D display, and decent for 3D (not for any new generation games, though).

The keyboard has a very positive feedback and feels good to type on for long download. A separate numeric keypad would be more than welcome, and there are just a few shortcut keys. The touchpad has a slippery finish, which is a bit irritating to move your fingers over. As far as response goes, though, the

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★●
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●



touchpad does fine.

The Sahara AL 096 costs a surprisingly high Rs 36,999. It lacks a webcam, a card reader, and even a microphone (so you need to connect an external one). Even the sound level of the speakers isn't audible even when there isn't much ambient sound. The battery life lasts two and a half hours—again, not impressive. The steep price isn't justified by Windows Vista Home Basic; there isn't any worthwhile bundled software either. To sum it

up, the price is just not right.

Specifications
Intel Core Duo T2250 1730 MHz; ATI Radeon XPRESS 200M (256 MB shared); 1 GB DDR2 533 MHz RAM; 120 GB 5400 rpm SATA hard drive; DVD multi-writer; Ports: 3xUSB 2.0, D-SUB, RJ-45, Modem; WiFi: 802.11g; Windows Vista Home Basic

Contact: Sahara Computers & Electronics Ltd
Phone: 95120-4397235
E-mail: info@saharacomputers.co.in
Web site: www.saharaglobal.com
Price: Rs 36,999

YES YMP45

You've gotta touch this one!

Featuring a rather large 2.4-inch colour touch-screen with a neon-red border, the YES YMP45 is encased in a black plastic case. It comes with 2 GB of internal memory, expandable with a Micro SD card (sadly, not hot-swappable). The device connects to the PC via USB and gets recognised as a MTP device if you have Windows Media Player 10 or above and lets you easily arrange and synchronise media content. You can also drag and drop content to it from Windows Explorer.

With the stock headphones, the YMP45 does quite well in the mid range, a little below decent in the highs and a little disappointing in the lows—it sounds a lot better with better cans. The highest volume levels aren't too

high though. Despite mentioning that lyrics are supported, MP3s with embedded lyrics didn't show any sign of the lyrics. There are only four preset equaliser settings, and you can't customise them.

Video playback is a bit choppy at 25 fps sometimes, but the YMP45 scores full marks with brilliant image quality. The player doesn't come with any software to convert your videos into a compatible format—disappointing. Do we even need to say that photos too look splendid?

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★★

The icon-based GUI is very easy to get used to and is very responsive to the accompanying stylus. Navigation in the video mode is a problem—no controls are visible (the video plays full screen) and you have to frantically keep moving the stylus around to figure it out for yourself.

Other features include an FM Radio that supports RDS (Radio Data Service—a European radio standard that lets the radio receive digital information about the content being transmitted). You can use it as a memo-recorder with the voice recorder feature, and can even read e-books! Fasten the accompanying Lanyard and it turns into a flashy pendant. The Li-Ion battery take around 3.5 hours to charge from the PC's USB port and last for just under three hours for video playback. The price—Rs 6,499—is fair.



Specifications
Capacity: 2 GB; Micro SD; Display: 2.4-inch 262K colour TFT touch-screen; Audio: MP3, WMA, WAV, OGG, AAC; Video: AVI, WMV; FM Radio with RDS; Dimensions: 76 (W) x 53 (D) x 13.3 (H) mm; Weight: 60 gm

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Price: Rs 70,000